Check-in Calls: Coordinator Setup Guide

How to start a volunteer check-in call program in a few weeks: for small charities, community groups, faith groups, libraries, and neighbour networks.

1. The program in one paragraph

Trained volunteers make regular, short, friendly phone calls to people who'd like more contact, usually **two calls a week for 4 to 8 weeks**. Volunteers listen with empathy and let the person lead the conversation. You, the coordinator, recruit and match people, run a short training session, keep an eye on calls and concerns, and handle anything beyond a friendly chat. **It is not therapy or a crisis service**, and you should say so clearly to everyone involved.

The approach is based on a randomized trial where briefly trained lay callers phoned 240 Meals on Wheels clients for 4 weeks (daily for the first 5 days, then at least twice a week, at times the person chose). Compared with people who got no calls, those who got calls were less lonely, less depressed, and less anxious after 4 weeks (Kahlon et al., *JAMA Psychiatry*, 2021). The trial didn't test whether benefits last beyond 4 weeks.

Roles

Role	What they do	Time
Coordinator (you; ideally with a named backup)	Recruits, matches, trains, monitors calls and concerns, is the safeguarding contact	2–4 hours a week, plus set-up
Volunteer callers	2 calls a week to 1–3 people, log calls, raise concerns	1–2 hours a week
Participants	Receive calls	Their choice

2. A timeline that works

When	What
Week −4	Decide who it's for and set your basic policies (Section 3). Put local crisis numbers in the app. Start recruiting volunteers.
Week −3	Ask referral partners for participants (Section 5). Interview volunteers; take references or checks if required.
Week −2	Consent calls with participants (Section 6). Run the training session (Section 8).
Week −1	Match volunteers and participants (Section 7). Set up pairings in the app. Optional: start-of-program loneliness check.
Weeks 1–4 (or 1–8)	Calls happen. Weekly coordinator routine (Section 9).
Final week	Final calls, end-of-program loneliness check, thank-yous, "what next" for each participant.
After	Short review with volunteers. Decide whether to run another round.

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3. Before you start: decisions and policies

Keep it simple, but write these down (one page is fine):

- **Who it's for.** For example "adults (18+) in our area who live alone or feel isolated." **Do not run one-to-one calls with under-18s** through this program. That needs a separate, specialist safeguarding approach.
- **Who it's not for.** People in acute mental-health crisis need crisis or clinical services, not a befriending call. You can still help them connect to those services.
- **Phone numbers.** Will volunteers use their own phones (with number withheld), a shared program phone, or a calling service? Withholding numbers protects volunteers' privacy, but some people won't answer unknown or withheld numbers. Agree an approach and tell participants what to expect.
- **Safeguarding lead.** Usually you. Name a backup for when you're away. Find your local adult safeguarding or adult protective services contact and add it to the app (Settings).
- **Crisis numbers.** Check which emergency number and crisis lines serve your participants. The app shows examples (988 in the US, Samaritans 116 123 in the UK and Ireland). Replace or add local ones; findahelpline.com lists free helplines by country.
- **Volunteer checks.** Follow the rules where you are, and your organization's own policy. Some places require formal background checks for volunteers who work with vulnerable adults (for example, DBS checks in England and Wales). At minimum, interview each volunteer and take a reference.
- **Data protection.** You'll hold names, phone numbers and brief notes about people. Collect only what you need, get consent, keep it secure, and delete it when it's no longer needed. If you're in a country with data-protection law (for example the UK GDPR or the EU GDPR), check what applies to your group. Larger organizations should involve whoever handles data protection.
- **Insurance.** Check whether your organization's insurance covers volunteer activities.

4. Recruiting volunteers

Where to find them: your own members and congregation; library notice boards; local volunteer centres; student volunteering offices (the trial's callers were 17 to 23 years old); retired people's groups; neighbourhood social-media groups.

Sample notice:

> **Could you spare an hour a week to brighten someone's day?** We're looking for friendly volunteers to make short check-in phone calls to local people who'd like more contact. No experience needed: just kindness, reliability and good listening. A free 2-hour training session is provided, and you'll have support throughout. Contact [name] on [number/email].

Look for: warmth, patience, reliability, comfort with silence, respect for boundaries, and willingness to ask for help.

A short interview (15–20 minutes) can cover: why they'd like to do it; their availability for the next 4–8 weeks; how they'd handle someone sounding very low (you're looking for "I'd tell the coordinator"); and any languages they speak.

Ask volunteers to commit to the full program period and to telling you early if they can't make a call.

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5. Finding participants

Referral partners often know exactly who would benefit:

- **GPs, family doctors, practice nurses**, and **social prescribing link workers** (in the UK, these are attached to GP practices)
- **Libraries** (home library services and regular visitors who mention being alone)
- **Faith groups** (pastoral care teams, visiting lists)
- **Meals on Wheels and food programs**, pharmacies, housing associations, carers' organizations, hospital discharge teams, bereavement services
- **Self-referral** and family or neighbours (with the person's agreement)

What to send referrers: a one-page description: who it's for, what it is ("friendly calls, not counselling"), how long it lasts, how to refer (with the person's permission), and your contact details.

Sample flyer text for participants:

> **Would you enjoy a friendly chat?** Our trained volunteers make short, regular phone calls to local people for a few weeks, at times that suit you. It's free, there's no catch, and you can stop any time. To find out more, call [name] on [number].

People on waiting lists. Many established befriending services have waits (Age UK, for example, lists an 8 to 10 week wait for its telephone befriending). A short program can bridge that gap. Tell people about other services too, so they don't lose their place elsewhere.

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6. The consent call

Before any volunteer calls, the coordinator should phone each person to explain the program and get their agreement. Record consent and the date in the app (Participants → consent recorded).

Consent script:

> "Hello, is that [name]? My name is [your name] from [organization]. [Referrer] mentioned you might like some friendly phone calls. Is now a good time to talk for five minutes?
>
> We have volunteers from the community who make short, friendly phone calls, usually [twice a week] for [four] weeks. It's just a chat about whatever you like. Our volunteers have had training, but they're not counsellors or medical professionals, and this isn't an emergency service.
>
> If you'd like to take part, I'd keep a few details: your name, phone number, the times that suit you, and an emergency contact if you're happy to give one. The volunteer will make short notes after each call, like 'we talked about the garden', so they remember what you chatted about. These details stay within our small team, on a password-protected device, and we delete them when the program ends [or after X months].
>
> The one exception: if we were ever seriously worried about your safety, we might need to contact someone, such as your emergency contact or emergency services. We'd try to talk to you about it first.
>
> You can stop the calls at any time, just by telling your volunteer or me.
>
> **Would you like to go ahead?** *(Wait for a clear yes.)*
>
> And would you be happy to answer three short questions about how you've been feeling, now and again at the end? It helps us know if the calls are useful. It's fine to say no. *(If yes, do the loneliness check: Section 10.)*
>
> Lastly, what days and times suit you best? Any language preference? Anything that would help, like calling a bit louder or letting it ring for longer?"

What to record: name, phone, preferred days/times, time zone (if not local), language, emergency contact (optional), consent (yes, with date), start date. In notes: anything practical that helps (e.g. "hard of hearing, let it ring 10 times").

If the person can't give consent themselves (for example, they seem confused about what's being offered), don't enrol them on a family member's word alone. Talk with the referrer about whether this program is right for them.

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7. Matching

Keep it practical. In order of importance:

1. **Availability:** the volunteer can reliably call at the times the participant wants.
2. **Language.**
3. **Any stated preference** (for example, some people prefer a caller of a particular gender).
4. **Shared interests:** nice to have, not essential. Good listening matters more than a perfect match.

Each volunteer: **1 to 3 participants** to begin with (the trial's callers each had 6 to 9, but they were dedicated and paid a small stipend). Introduce them through the first call; there's no need for anything more formal.

In the app: **Pairings** → **New pairing**. Choose the volunteer, participant, call days (one day = weekly, two days = twice weekly), time, start date and end date. Calls appear automatically on the Upcoming page.

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8. Training session (about 1.5 to 2 hours)

The trial used about an hour of video training, so this can be short. Give each volunteer the **Volunteer Training Guide** beforehand, and print the quick-reference card.

Time	Topic	How
0:00–0:10	Welcome, introductions, why loneliness matters	Short talk; share the evidence page (Guide, Section 3)
0:10–0:20	What the program is and isn't; boundaries	Go through the Do / Don't table
0:20–0:45	**Empathetic listening**: let them lead, open questions, reflecting	Demo a good and a bad call; pairs practise turning closed questions into open ones
0:45–1:05	**Role-play in pairs**: first call, then a regular call	Use the scripts; swap roles; quick group debrief
1:05–1:10	Break	
1:10–1:35	**Warning signs and the crisis protocol**	Walk through the three levels (immediate danger / suicidal thoughts / non-urgent). Role-play one gentle scenario: "I don't see the point anymore." Practise asking directly and contacting the coordinator. Show the crisis numbers.
1:35–1:45	Confidentiality, notes, no recording	Show a good note vs a bad note
1:45–1:55	Logging calls in the app (or how to report to you); what to do if they can't make a call	Live demo with sample data
1:55–2:00	Self-care, questions, next steps	Give out the quick-reference card; confirm everyone's first-call date

Afterwards, mark **Training completed** with the date on each volunteer's record.

Tips: keep role-plays light and voluntary; don't use real participant stories. Make sure everyone leaves knowing **one thing above all: if you're worried, tell the coordinator.**

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9. Running the program (4 to 8 weeks)

Your weekly routine (about 30–60 minutes)

1. **Check Concerns** (the red badge in the app). Urgent ones: act the same day. Follow-ups: within 24 hours. Write what you did in the resolution notes, then mark resolved.
2. **Check Upcoming → Overdue.** Chase unlogged calls. If someone has missed two calls in a row, try calling them yourself, then their emergency contact if you're worried.
3. **Check in with each volunteer**: a short text or call. "How are your calls going? Anything on your mind?"
4. **Export a backup** (Settings → Export backup). Store it somewhere secure.

Handling concerns

- **Urgent** (risk to life, suicidal thoughts, harm or abuse): make sure the volunteer has followed the crisis protocol; follow up with the participant; involve their emergency contact, GP, crisis line, or safeguarding services as needed; support the volunteer.
- **Follow-up** (practical needs, low mood, missed calls): call the participant, signpost to local services (carers' support, food, benefits advice, local groups), and note what happened.
- **If a volunteer is upset by a call**, talk to them the same day.

Ending well

- From about two calls before the end, volunteers remind participants the program is finishing.
- In the final week: final call, end-of-program loneliness check, and a **"what next" conversation** for each participant. Options might be another round of calls, a local group, or a volunteering opportunity. Recurring group activities and volunteering are worth suggesting; in one large study, widowed adults who volunteered at least 2 hours a week had loneliness levels close to those of married peers (Carr et al., 2018).
- Thank volunteers, ask what worked, and set participants' status to **Ended** in the app (this keeps the records but stops the calls).

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10. Measuring results: the 3-item UCLA Loneliness Scale

The **3-item UCLA Loneliness Scale** (Hughes, Waite, Hawkley & Cacioppo, 2004) was designed for telephone surveys and is quick to ask. It was the main loneliness measure in the Kahlon trial.

How to ask (at the consent call or first call, and again at the final call):

> "The next questions are about how you feel about different aspects of your life. For each one, tell me how often you feel that way: hardly ever, some of the time, or often."
>
> 1. How often do you feel that you lack companionship?
> 2. How often do you feel left out?

> 3. How often do you feel isolated from others?

Scoring: Hardly ever = 1, Some of the time = 2, Often = 3. Add them up: **3 to 9, where higher means lonelier**. Some researchers have grouped scores of 6–9 as "lonely" (Healthy Aging NC summary). In the Kahlon trial, people who got calls scored about **1.1 points lower** than those who didn't after 4 weeks.

In the app: Stats → Record a loneliness check. Choose "Start" or "End". The Stats page shows each person's change and the average change.

Be honest about what this shows. Without a comparison group, you can't be sure the calls caused any change, and small groups give noisy numbers. Treat results as a helpful signal, alongside what participants and volunteers tell you.

A simple end-of-round summary: number of participants and volunteers; calls completed; missed-call rate; average change in loneliness score (and how many people had both scores); concerns raised and how they were handled; two or three anonymous quotes (with permission). This is useful for funders, partners, and your own learning.

Other things worth tracking: calls completed per week, missed-call rate (the app calculates this), volunteer retention, and how many participants went on to something else.

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11. Using the app

The app is a single file (`app/index.html`). Open it in any modern browser (Chrome, Edge, Firefox, Safari). It works offline and needs no account or installation.

Important: one device

All data is stored only in the browser on the device where you use it. It does not sync between devices or people. For v1, the simplest setup is:

- **The coordinator keeps the app on one password-protected device**, and volunteers report each call by text, phone or email (outcome, mood 1–5, a one-line note, any concern). The coordinator logs it.
- Or, a volunteer can run their own copy for just their own participants, and send the coordinator a CSV export each week. (Concerns must still be reported to the coordinator straight away, by phone.)

Never put the file and its data on a shared or public computer.

First-time setup (15 minutes)

1. Open `index.html`. Optionally click **Load sample data** to explore, then **Clear all data** when you're ready to start for real.
2. **Settings:** enter your organization name, your name, phone and email, your safeguarding contact, and your **local crisis numbers** (check the examples). Save.
3. **Volunteers:** add each volunteer; tick **Training completed** after the session.
4. **Participants:** add each person, tick **Consent recorded**, and set status to Active.

5. **Pairings:** link volunteer and participant with call days, time, start and end dates.
6. **Export a backup** (Settings).

Day to day

- **Upcoming calls** shows the next 14 days, with **today highlighted in yellow** and **overdue or unlogged calls in red** (last 14 days).
- **Log call** records the outcome (completed / no answer / rescheduled), length, mood, notes, and any concern. Choosing **Urgent** shows the crisis protocol straight away, and a red banner stays at the top of every page until the concern is resolved.
- **Concerns** lists open concerns, urgent first, with the participant's phone and emergency contact. Add resolution notes and mark resolved.
- **Stats** shows calls this week and month, missed-call rate, active participants, average mood, loneliness scores, and calls per volunteer.
- ⚠️ **Crisis protocol** (top right) is always one tap away.
- **Print** on the Upcoming page gives a paper call sheet.

Backups and data

- **Export backup (JSON)** weekly, and before clearing browser data or changing devices. **Import backup** restores it (this replaces what's on the device).
- **Export call log (CSV)** opens in any spreadsheet program for reporting.
- Backup files contain personal information. Store them securely, and delete old ones you don't need.
- When the program ends and you no longer need the records, export what you need for reporting (anonymised), then use **Clear all data**.

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12. Checklist

- ☐ Who it's for written down; adults only
- ☐ Coordinator and backup named; safeguarding contact found
- ☐ Local emergency number and crisis lines checked and entered in the app
- ☐ Volunteer interview, references and any required checks done
- ☐ Training session held; quick-reference cards given out
- ☐ Consent recorded for every participant
- ☐ Pairings set up; first calls confirmed
- ☐ Weekly routine in your diary (concerns, overdue calls, volunteer check-ins, backup)
- ☐ Start and end loneliness checks (optional)
- ☐ End-of-program "what next" for every participant; volunteer thank-you and review

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Sources

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- 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline. Help Someone Else. https://988lifeline.org/help-someone-else/
- Samaritans (UK & Ireland): 116 123. https://www.samaritans.org/
- Find A Helpline (international directory): https://findahelpline.com